

Two arguments for a movement analysis of Negative Doubling

Tommaso Mattiuzzi, Giacomo Presotto, and Cecilia Poletto*

1 Introduction

We present evidence from Northern Italian Dialects that supports a movement-analysis of Negative Doubling, the subtype of Negative Concord (NC) in which a single-negation interpretation arises despite the co-occurrence of a negative marker with one or more negative indefinites (Zeijlstra 2004). In movement-based analyses, sentential negation is base-merged as part of a negative indefinite and is then split from it in later steps of the derivation (Blanchette 2015, Tubau et al. 2024, Presotto et al. submitted). This perspective diverges from the more widely adopted Agree-based analyses, which capture Negative Doubling (and NC in general) in terms of the presence of negative formal features scattered across the clausal structure and related via Agree (Haegeman and Lohndal 2010, Manzini and Pescarini 2024, Zeijlstra 2004, 2022). In this work, we show that movement-based analyses make empirical predictions that cannot be formulated in terms of an Agree-based perspective and are borne out by data from two distinct varieties spoken in Northern Italy.

2 Syntactic approaches to negative Doubling

The distribution and interpretation of negative elements across languages defines a rather intricate empirical landscape. Some languages treat the co-occurrence of multiple negative elements as the recursive application of negation, yielding an affirmative interpretation when negation is expressed twice. This is descriptively referred to as a Double Negation (DN) system and is traditionally associated with languages such as German and Dutch. By contrast, other languages interpret co-occurring negative elements as contributing a unique, semantically shared negation, thereby yielding a Single Negation (SN) interpretation. Within the latter group, traditionally referred to as NC languages, two further subtypes are distinguished: Strict and Non-Strict NC languages. In Strict NC languages (e.g. Czech and Polish), a negative marker must obligatorily co-occur with a negative indefinite. In Non-Strict NC languages (e.g. Italian and Spanish), by contrast, the distribution of the negative marker depends on the position of the co-occurring negative indefinite. An NC configuration is obligatory whenever a negative indefinite occurs postverbally (where it is c-commanded by the negative marker), whereas preverbal negative indefinites cannot co-occur with a negative marker without yielding ungrammaticality or, at best, a DN interpretation.¹

In light of this cross-linguistic complexity, a number of theoretical approaches to NC have been proposed. Although these differ substantially in their assumptions about the nature of negative elements and the mechanisms responsible for deriving NC interpretations, they all seek to address the same question: when, and how, are two negative elements interpreted as a single semantic negation? Haegeman & Zanuttini (1991) propose that negative markers and Negative Concord Items (NCIs) are both inherently negative, and undergo a process of *negative absorption*, whereby the negative meaning of a raised indefinite is cancelled under the scope of a negative operator. Other approaches instead focus on whether (and how) the negative features of NCIs are syntactically visible to the projection encoding sentential polarity, based on conditions on cross-phase transparency (Déprez 1997, Manzini and Pescarini 2024). Arguably the most influential approach, however, is the Agree-based system developed by Zeijlstra (2004, 2022). On this view, NC results from (Multiple) Agree between so-called *n*-items, including negative indefinites, negative markers, and, in some languages, a silent negative operator. *N*-items bear one of two possible instantiations of the formal [Neg] feature: [iNeg] or [uNeg]. Only elements bearing [iNeg] receive a semantic negative interpretation,

*We are grateful to Katharina Hartmann, Manfred Sailer, Hedde Zeijlstra, as well as to the audience at PLC50, for valuable comments. All errors are our own.

¹For comprehensive overviews of this typology and its many interesting refinements and deviations, see a.o. den Besten (1989), Giannakidou and Zeijlstra (2017), Blanchette (2015), Déprez et al. (2015), and Weiß (2025).

whereas elements bearing [uNeg] are (morpho-)syntactically marked for negation but interpreted as mere existentials. An NC reading arises when one or more [uNeg] items enter into an Agree relation with an [iNeg] item, with [uNeg] items probing upwards (Zeijlstra 2012). In this work, we provide empirical evidence in support of a fourth approach to NC, represented by movement-based analyses in which negative features in NC configurations originate as a single structural unit within the vP, before being split in the course of the derivation (Blanchette 2015, Tubau et al. 2024, Presotto et al. submitted).

3 Occitan Data

The first empirical argument is that if Negative Doubling arises as the derivational split of a single constituent, there should be cases where this original constituent is overtly observed. Evidence bearing out this prediction comes from dialects spoken in Western Piedmont, such as the Franco-provençal variety of Ramats. There, the negative marker *pâ* surfaces in a postverbal position (1a). When a negative indefinite like *gî* ‘anybody/nobody’ is in postverbal position, like in (1b), the two elements co-occur. However, when a negative indefinite is preverbal as in (1c), the two items surface as a single unit.²

- (1) a. A vouran **pâ** anâ-lhi. (Ramats, data from the ASiT database)
 SBJ want.3PL NEG go-there
 ‘They don’t want to go there.’
 b. Lù’ ei **pâ** arrivá **gî**.
 SBJ.3 has NEG arrived anybody
 ‘Nobody arrived.’
 c. **Pagî** o minjá la soupo.
 NEG.anybody has eaten the soup
 ‘Nobody ate the soup.’

The same pattern is observed in another variety from the same area, spoken in the village of Coazze (documented by Manzini and Savoia (2005)), where the negative indefinite corresponding to ‘anybody/nobody’ is /*ɲyɲ*/. Again, the regular sentential negator *pa* occupies a postverbal position (2a) and co-occurs with a postverbal negative indefinite (2b). When a negative indefinite instead occurs in preverbal position, *pa* surfaces adjacent to it.

- (2) a. u lu 'tʃamat 'pa. (Coazze, data from Manzini and Savoia (2005))
 SBJ.3SG OBJ.3SG call.3SG NEG
 ‘He does not call him.’
 b. u ø **pa** tʃa'ma 'ɲyɲ
 SBJ.3SG have.3SG NEG call.PTCP anybody
 ‘He didn’t call anybody.’
 c. **pa** 'ɲyɲ a 'mɪɲdʒat.
 NEG anybody have.3SG eat.PTCP
 ‘Nobody ate.’

In both cases, the crucial observation is that the negator does not appear in its regular postverbal position when a negative indefinite surfaces preverbally, as in (1c) and (2c). Since this is conditioned by the movement of the indefinite *gî*/*ɲyɲ*, the simplest account of the pattern is one where the negator *pâ* and a negative indefinite *gî*/*ɲyɲ* originally form a constituent that can appear either as a whole or split, as expected under a movement-based analysis.

²Note that we adhere to the writing conventions adopted by the ASiT informants from Ramats, who write *pagî* as a single word in this context. This provides indirect support for the idea that they perceive *pagî* as a single unit.

4 Veneto Data

The second empirical argument comes from a corollary of the movement-based perspective: in sentences that do not contain any negative indefinite, the sentential negative marker must have a different base-merge site. If this is the case, its structural properties are different depending on the presence or absence of a Negative Doubling configuration, and it should be in principle possible to observe morphological alternations tracking this difference. One such alternation occurs in the variety of Sant'Anna di Chioggia (Veneto), as shown in the fieldwork data we present below: the sentential negative marker there is the preverbal clitic *no* (3a), unless the sentence contains a Negative Doubling configuration (3b), in which case the marker takes on a different form, *ne*:

- (3) a. A **no** magno pomi S. Anna di Chioggia (Veneto)
 SBJ not eat.1SG apples
 'I don't eat apples.'
 b. A **ne** magna **nisun**.
 SBJ not eat.3 nobody
 'Nobody eats.'

Such alternation is problematic for Agree-based analyses, where the status of the sentential negative marker is not affected by the presence of negative indefinites. Depending on the specific pattern and analysis, a marker like *no* (or *pâ* above) either carries interpretable negative features and is the Goal for negative indefinites carrying negative probes, or is itself dependent on some other covert element carrying negative features on a par with negative indefinites. In both scenarios, the merger and featural make-up of the sentential negative marker is constant: an iNeg negative marker remains one whether or not it enters a dependency with any uNeg element, and a uNeg one requires some iNeg element licensing it regardless of whether the sentence contains any negative words. But if both the Merge position and the featural make-up of the sentential negator are the same, there is no rationale for why its surface realisation should change under Negative Doubling.

The situation is different under a movement-based approach. Regardless of the details of the analysis, the core idea is that what is realised as a sentential negator under Negative Doubling is a subpart of the structure containing a negative indefinite, and this establishes a distinction between the status of sentential negators in sentences with and without Negative Doubling dependencies.

An additional piece of evidence supports this view: as shown in (4), the same form of the negative clitic found when the negator enters a doubling configuration with a negative indefinite (as in (3b)) is found in bipartite negative structures consisting of the clitic plus a postverbal adverbial element (*mine* in this variety, a cognate of the analogous Italian adverb *mica*, see Cinque (1977, 1999), Frana and Rawlins (2019), Magistro (2022)).³

- (4) A **ne** magno **mina** pomi. S. Anna di Chioggia (Veneto)
 SBJ not eat.1SG at.all apples
 'I don't eat apples at all.'

An influential proposal about the structural status of such bipartite negative structures ever since Pollock's (1989) analysis of French *ne...pas* is that the two parts of the negator are base generated in the same constituent and split by subsequent movement operations – in Pollock's proposal, by head-movement of the verb incorporating the negative head *ne*, which then moves along with it to a higher position in the structure. The fact that the form taken by the negative clitic is the same under Negative Doubling and in bipartite negation therefore indicates that the same type of dependency is at stake, one that tears these contexts apart from cases in which the clitic is the only negative form in the sentence as in (3a). A movement-based approach to Negative Doubling captures this common behaviour by extending to this type of dependency a proposal about bipartite negative structures that has long been advanced on independent grounds.

³This bipartite structure shares the behaviour of its Italian counterpart as a means to express emphatic negation. Here, we are interested in its structural status as a two-part negator and hence abstract away from any semantic or pragmatic considerations.

5 A movement-based approach to Negative Doubling

While both arguments represent evidence in favour of movement-based analyses in general, we argue that the most straightforward way to capture these patterns is to treat Negative Doubling on a par with other well-known instances of syntactic doubling like the clitic doubling of arguments attested in Romance languages, commonly analysed as the splitting of a ‘big DP’ (Kayne 1975, Uriagereka 1995, Poletto 2008). We claim that Negative Doubling arises in a similar fashion as a result of the way languages satisfy a general licensing requirement for negative features (parallel to the ϕ -features of clitic-doubled arguments). Languages with Negative Doubling must license negative polarity features by (re-)merging a negative item in a fixed structural position, which varies across languages (as richly documented by Zanuttini 1997). In a negative sentence with no negative indefinites, negative polarity will be marked by directly merging the sentential negator in this position, which – following Laka (1991) – we dub PolP in (5b).

- (5) a. Gianni **non** viene.
 Gianni NEG come.3SG
 ‘Gianni doesn’t come.’
 b.
-
- ```

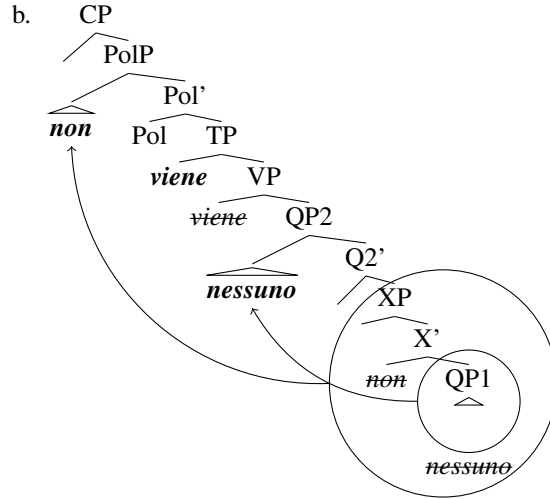
graph TD
 CP --> SubjP
 CP --> PolP
 SubjP --> Gianni1[Gianni]
 PolP --> non
 PolP --> TP
 TP --> viene1[viene]
 TP --> VP
 VP --> viene2[viene]
 VP --> Gianni2[Gianni]

```

By present assumptions, the structure of negative indefinites contains negative features. This is not sufficient to yield a well-formed negative sentence in Negative Doubling languages, since they share the requirement that negative polarity be licensed in a specific position in the clause. Crucially, licensing can be achieved either by moving the whole negative indefinite or by splitting it and moving only its negative sub-part to the target position.

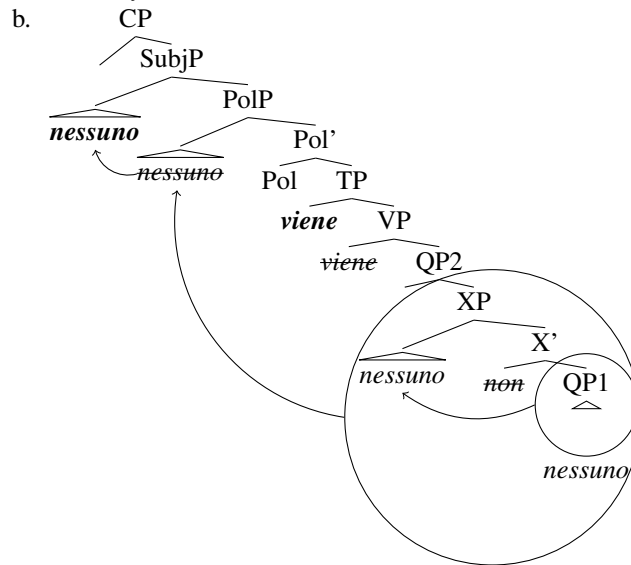
From this perspective, the derivation of a doubling configuration like (6a) in a textbook non-strict NC language like Italian is as in (6b). A subpart of the negative indefinite *nessuno* (QP1) moves to a position internal to the structure of the negative quantifier (SpecQP2), from which it can further move out of the extended QP and reach its surface position. This movement creates a remnant constituent containing *non*, here agnostically labelled XP. When the derivation of the structure reaches the position where Italian licenses negative polarity, XP (containing the negative features lexicalised by the negative clitic *non*) is raised.

- (6) a. Non viene nessuno. (Italian)  
 NEG come.PTCP nobody  
 ‘Nobody comes.’



When a negative indefinite appears in preverbal position, no overt negative marker is realised (7a), as typical of non-strict NC systems. In this case, the target position of the negative indefinite is above PolP, and so it is in principle possible for the negative indefinite to license negative polarity in PolP by pied-piping negative features as it moves to its target position higher up in the clausal structure (here, the position of preverbal subjects, which we dub SubjP<sup>4</sup>). We model this as the result of movement of the lower portion of the negative QP to SpecXP, yielding a doubly-filled Comp effect which makes the lexicalisation of *non* impossible (see e.g. Koopman 1997, 2006, Collins 2007 for discussion of this mechanism). This forces the negative indefinite to pied-pipe XP and move to Spec,PolP to check its polarity features on its way to SubjP (7b).

- (7) a. Nessuno viene.  
nobody come.3SG  
'Nobody comes.'



Taking stock, this implementation of an analysis of Negative Doubling as movement for a non-strict NC concord system like Italian involves an articulated internal structure of the negative indefinite and two different possible movements of the indefinite component: in one case, the indefinite is split from the negative features in XP (as in (6b)); in the other, it enters a Spec-Head relation

<sup>4</sup>We remain agnostic as to the exact status of preverbal subjects in a language like Italian. Note, however, that the assumption of SubjP or an equivalent position higher than TP is virtually forced by assuming that the clitic negator is higher than TP, since subjects cannot intervene between the clitic negator and the inflected verb.

with them, whereby it subsequently behaves as the element carrying sentential negative features and licensing negation in PolP (7b).

Note that these postulates are independent of the two core claims advanced above, namely that, in languages with Negative Doubling, a) negative features are base-generated inside the structure of negative indefinites, and b) sentential negation must be licensed in a fixed structural position. This leaves two aspects open to variation, namely the specific structural position where negation is licensed (as already observed since at least Pollock 1989, Zanuttini 1997, Laka 1991) and the particular derivation through which this requirement is satisfied.

The goal of this section is merely to illustrate one possible implementation of a movement analysis of Negative Doubling compliant with the observations from Northern Italian Dialects discussed above. We therefore leave it to future work to fully work out a complete typology of Negative Doubling systems in terms of this lower-level parametrisation. At this stage, we limit ourselves to pointing out how a different Negative Doubling system may arise. Of the two (groups of) Northern Italian Dialects, the variety of S. Anna di Chioggia exhibits a system analogous to that of Italian, with sentential negation in preverbal position. As shown in section 4, the twist with respect to the Italian patterns just discussed is that the contrast between the negative constituent base-generated in PolP (as in (5b)) and an XP raised from inside the structure of a negative indefinite is tracked by a distinct lexicalisation. The system of Occitan varieties like those discussed in section 3, instead, differs from Italian with respect to both parameters identified above.

The first difference concerns the structural position where negation is licensed. As shown above, these Occitan varieties have a postverbal sentential negator *pa*. In view of this contrast and the rich variation in the position of sentential negators already identified in the literature (Zanuttini 1997, Poletto 2020), we assume *pa* to surface in a low position between TP and the position occupied by past participles. Occitan also differs from Italian in that the negative marker *pa* is never omitted: it is split from the indefinite when the latter is postverbal and is realised adjacent to it otherwise. We take this to reflect a difference between the negative quantifiers in the two types of languages. In Italian (or the Veneto variety of S. Anna), a negative indefinite like *nessuno* ‘nobody’ possesses negative features, which allow it to move to SpecXP, trigger the non-realisation of the negative clitic and surface as the sole marker of sentential negation (see the derivation in (7b)). Elements like Occitan *gî*, on the other hand, must always be preceded by the negator *pa*, either in a (potentially) discontinuous sequence below T or strictly adjacent to it above T. On this basis, we treat them as analogous to strict NPIs in requiring c-command from a negative operator, an analytical choice reflected by our glossing *gî* as ‘anybody’. Further support for this view comes from the observation that when the sentence is introduced by a *without*-complementiser in Ramats, the indefinite appears as *gî* alone even in preverbal position, as shown in (8).

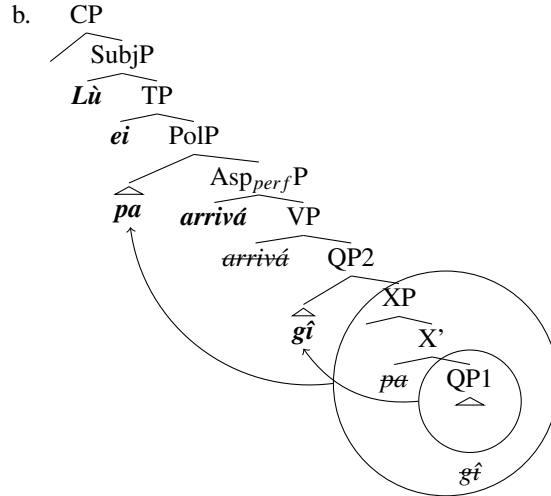
- (8) sanso quë *gî* ou’s fatigue (Ramats, Occitan)  
 without that anybody SBJ.3.REFL.3 get.tired.SBJV.3  
 ‘before anybody gets tired.’

Relevant for present purposes, the different status of e.g. *gî* with respect to *nessuno* makes it impossible for the former to license negation on its own – on our analysis, to move to SpecXP.<sup>5</sup>

The derivation of a configuration with a postverbal negative indefinite like (9a) is as in (9b). Parallel to the analysis in (6a), the indefinite *gî* moves to SpecQP, leaving an XP remnant which then moves to SpecPolP, resulting in the split of *pa* from the rest of the structure of the quantifier.

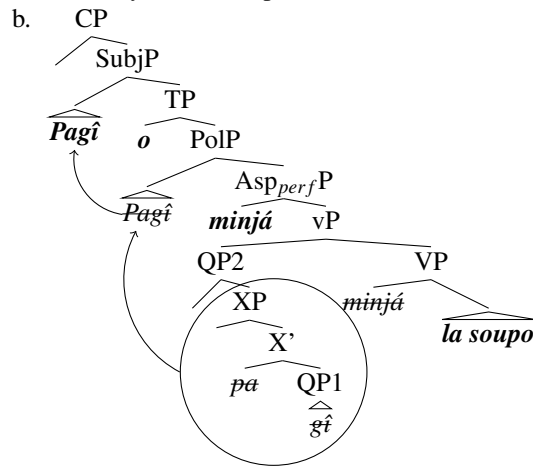
- (9) a. Lù’ ei pâ arrivá *gî*. (Ramats, Occitan)  
 SBJ.3 has NEG arrived anybody  
 ‘Nobody arrived.’

<sup>5</sup>Extending the perspective to other Romance languages, the connection between NCIs like *nessuno* and NPIs like *gî* is paralleled by the observation that elements like Spanish *nada* ‘nothing’, French *rien* ‘nothing’ or *personne* ‘nobody’, etc. all originated from non-negative NPIs and acquired the ability to license sentential negation on their own, despite not exhibiting negative morphology.



Whenever the licensing position of the indefinite is instead above the licensing site of negation (as with the preverbal subject in (10a)), the same sequence of movements sets the stage for the later movement of a remnant QP2 containing *gî* alone to a position c-commanding *pa*. As we argued above, this is banned by the status of elements like *gî*, which must be c-commanded by a negative marker. As shown in (10b), convergence is reached by avoiding internal movement to SpecQP2. Since *gî* stays *in situ*, movement of XP to (the low) PolP pied-pipes it. Once the derivation reaches the position where the indefinite must be licensed, the latter has already moved as part of XP. At this point, subextracting *gî* and moving it alone would again result in the unlicensed c-command relation. XP therefore keeps moving as a unit under pied-piping. This results in the items lexicalising negative features (*pa*) and the indefinite (*gî*) surfacing together in preverbal position, despite negative features being licensed lower in the structure.

- (10) a. *Pagî o minjá la soupo.*  
 NEG.anybody has eaten the soup  
 ‘Nobody ate the soup.’



## 6 Conclusions and open issues

In this paper, we have presented two empirical arguments supporting a movement-based approach to Negative Doubling. Data from Northern Italian dialects show that this perspective captures patterns that remain unexpected under Agree-based analyses. We have also argued that these patterns can be naturally accommodated within a specific implementation of a movement-based account, which extends independently motivated ideas about constituent splitting and syntactic doubling to the domain

of NC. The technical details of the proposed derivations, and the questions they raise, are addressed more fully in Presotto et al. (submitted) and remain subject to further refinement.

More generally, these findings once again highlight the importance of fine-grained microvariation for evaluating and refining syntactic theories.

## References

- den Besten, Johannes B. 1989. *Studies in West Germanic Syntax*. Doctoral dissertation, Tilburg University, Amsterdam.
- Blanchette, Frances K. 2015. *English Negative Concord, Negative Polarity, and Double Negation*. Doctoral dissertation, Graduate Center, The City University of New York, New York, NY, USA. Doctoral dissertation.
- Cinque, Guglielmo. 1977. *Mica*. *Annali della Facoltà di Lettere e Filosofia dell'Università di Padova* 1:101–112.
- Cinque, Guglielmo. 1999. *Adverbs and Functional Heads: A Cross-Linguistic Perspective*. Oxford Studies in Comparative Syntax. New York / Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Collins, Chris. 2007. Home sweet home. Published: NYU working papers in linguistics.
- Déprez, Viviane. 1997. Two types of negative concord. *Probus* 9:103–143.
- Déprez, Viviane, Susagna Tubau, Anne Cheylus, and M. Teresa Espinal. 2015. Double Negation in a Negative Concord language: An experimental investigation. *Lingua* 163:75–107.
- Frana, Ilaria, and Kyle Rawlins. 2019. Attitudes in discourse: Italian polar questions and the particle mica. *Semantics and Pragmatics* 12:1–55.
- Giannakidou, Anastasia, and Hedde Zeijlstra. 2017. The landscape of negative dependencies: Negative concord and n-words. In *The Wiley Blackwell Companion to Syntax, Second Edition*, 1–38. John Wiley & Sons, Ltd.
- Haegeman, Liliane, and Terje Lohndal. 2010. Negative concord and (multiple) agree: A case study of west flemish. *Linguistic Inquiry* 41:181–211.
- Kayne, Richard S. 1975. *French syntax: The transformational cycle*, volume 30. MIT press Cambridge, MA.
- Koopman, Hilda. 1997. The doubly filled c filter, the principle of projection activation, and historical change. Published: Ms. UCLA.
- Koopman, Hilda. 2006. Agreement configurations: In defense of “spec head”. In *Agreement systems*, ed. Cedric Boeckx, 159–199. John Benjamins.
- Laka, Itziar. 1991. Negation in syntax: on the nature of functional categories and projections. *Anuario del Seminario de Filología Vasca "Julio de Urquijo"* 25:65–136.
- Magistro, Giuseppe. 2022. Mica preposing as focus fronting. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 7.
- Manzini, M. Rita, and Diego Pescarini. 2024. Negative concord by phase: multiple downward agree and the parametrization of edge features. *The Linguistic Review* 41:661–698.
- Manzini, M. Rita, and Leonardo Savoia. 2005. *I Dialecti Italiani e Romanci: Morfosintassi Generativa*. Alessandria: Edizioni dell’Orso.
- Poletto, Cecilia. 2008. The syntax of focus negation. *Quaderni di Lavoro ASIt* 10:39–61.
- Poletto, Cecilia. 2020. The possible positioning of negation. In *The Oxford Handbook of Negation*, ed. Viviane Déprez and M. Teresa Espinal, 135–151. Oxford University Press, 1 edition.
- Pollock, Jean-Yves. 1989. Verb movement, universal grammar, and the structure of IP. *Linguistic inquiry* 20:365–424.
- Presotto, Giacomo, Tommaso Mattiuzzi, and Cecilia Poletto. submitted. Negative doubling is doubling. Submitted.
- Tubau, Susagna, Urtzi Etxeberria, and M. Teresa Espinal. 2024. A new approach to negative concord: Catalan as a case in point. *Journal of Linguistics* 60:757–789.
- Uriagereka, Juan. 1995. Aspects of the syntax of clitic placement in western romance. *Linguistic Inquiry* 26:79–123.
- Weiß, Helmut. 2025. Neg-words: What they are and what they are not and what follows from this. *Evolutionary Linguistic Theory* 1–27.
- Zanuttini, Raffaella. 1997. *Negation and Clausal Structure: A Comparative Study of Romance Languages*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2004. *Sentential negation and negative concord*. Number 101 in LOT. Utrecht: LOT.
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2012. There is only one way to agree. *The Linguistic Review* 29:491–539.
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2022. *Negation and Negative Dependencies*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1 edition.



SFB “Negation in Language and Beyond”  
Goethe-Universität Frankfurt | Campus Westend | IG-Farben-Haus  
Frankfurt am Main, 60323  
*mattiuzzi@em.uni-frankfurt.de*